



Maritime &
Coastguard
Agency

Guidance

Safety Bulletin 19: Corroded cartridge type fire extinguishers

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Summary of issue

Following a recent fatal accident on board an oil rig it has been highlighted that greater awareness of the risks from corrosion to cartridge type fire extinguishers is required. A Marine Safety Forum Safety alert (Number 21-11) has already been published as a result of this accident and this MCA safety alert repeats much of this alert.

Cartridge type fire extinguishers are widely used in the maritime sector and when properly maintained and inspected offer a safe and effective fire extinguishing solution, however when affected by corrosion there is a significant risk to users.

Actions to take

During regular inspection routines, vessel personnel shall inspect cartridge type fire extinguishers exposed to the weather for corrosion. Fire extinguishers should be mounted off the deck/floor in manufacturer approved mounting devices that reduce the chance of moisture from being trapped under the fire extinguisher where practical. In all cases the portable extinguishers shall be secured by a means not liable to seize and capable of ready release without the use of tools

All portable and non-portable fire extinguishers should be maintained by a “Competent Person” in accordance with MGN 276.

Fire extinguisher disposal shall only be conducted by qualified third-party personnel as per the manufacturer’s specifications (or regulatory requirements). Condemned fire extinguishers shall never be discharged by vessel personnel. Where a fire extinguisher is found to be corroded it shall be removed and stored in a suitable place until it can be disposed of by qualified personnel.

Cartridge-Type Fire Extinguishers that utilise a cartridge to charge the main fire extinguisher cylinder shall be handled with care: The fire extinguisher should be placed on the deck at arm’s length from the body. Point the top of the extinguisher away from the body while holding the handle and hose in one hand. Trigger the carbon dioxide charging cylinder with the other hand. Do not energise these types of fire extinguishers near the body.

It is not always immediately obvious where portable fire extinguishers are cartridge type, this can be determined by looking at the refill instructions which will be found on the cylinder body.

Further information

The MSF Safety Alert can be found at [MSF 21-11](https://www.marinesafetyforum.org/safety-alerts/fatality-caused-by-explosion-of-corroded-fire-extinguisher/) (<https://www.marinesafetyforum.org/safety-alerts/fatality-caused-by-explosion-of-corroded-fire-extinguisher/>).

The following documents provide guidance for the maintenance of portable fire extinguishers:

- [MGN 276 - Maintenance of portable fire extinguishers.](https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/mgn-276-maintenance-of-portable-fire-extinguishers) (<https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/mgn-276-maintenance-of-portable-fire-extinguishers>)
- [MGN 374 - Periodic inspection and testing of seamless steel pressurised gas cylinders.](https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/mgn-374-inspection-and-testing-of-steel-pressurised-gas-cylinders) (<https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/mgn-374-inspection-and-testing-of-steel-pressurised-gas-cylinders>)
- [IMO Res.A.951\(23\) - Improved guidelines for marine portable fire extinguishers.](https://www.imorules.com/IMORES_A951.23.html) (https://www.imorules.com/IMORES_A951.23.html)



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